



Gdojo: Jiu-Jitsu Reflections

MARTIAL ARTS · BIOMECHANICS · LONGEVITY

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FRAMEWORK

Open or *Closed*?

One question every practitioner should ask before every movement — and why your spine holds the answer.

FOR PRACTITIONERS & INSTRUCTORS
BJJ · JUDO · LONGEVITY
A CARBON & SILICON COLLABORATION

"Maximum efficiency with minimum effort."

JIGORO KANO · FOUNDER OF JUDO*

"Work smarter, not harder."

ALLEN F. MORGENSTERN, 1930S**

INTRODUCTION

It Started with Pain

I wasn't trying to build a framework. I was trying to fix my back. I've been training since 1995 — thirty years on the mat — and somewhere along the way, lower back pain, shoulder tightness, and cervical stress became things I just lived with. I'd looked into the Alexander Technique years earlier, searching for something that would address the root cause rather than just manage symptoms. The answers were there, but scattered.

Then I watched Justin Flores ([J FLO](#) — 3x National Judo Champion, Division I wrestler, Jiu-Jitsu black belt, 2020 USA Olympic team coach, 3x UFC World Champion coach, and world-class teacher of grappling)[†], talk about keeping the hips springy. His cue was simple: turn your toes inward. That adjustment, he explained, keeps the hips alive and springy — loose, reactive, ready to move in any direction. Something clicked. I started connecting it to what I already knew from Wing Chun's pigeon-toed stance, to the way anterior pelvic tilt cascades up from

duck foot posture and loads the lumbar spine. The problems weren't isolated. They were downstream effects of a broken foundation.

I'm turning fifty this year. I intend to keep training. That means longevity isn't optional — it's the whole game. And what I discovered through that process of fixing my own body is a framework I believe every practitioner and instructor should be thinking about consciously: **the open and closed spine.**

"The problems weren't isolated. They were downstream effects of a broken foundation."

This isn't academic theory — it's pattern recognition drawn from lived practice, cross-referenced with the biomechanics literature and tested on the mat. I'm still building it. But the essential question is already clear enough to share:

For this position, this movement, this moment — do you want an open spine or a closed spine?

THE FRAMEWORK

The Two Spines

Every martial arts position places a demand on your spine. The question is whether that demand is best met with spinal flexion — a concave, inward-curved posture — or spinal extension — an upright, open posture. We'll call these **Closed Spine** and **Open Spine**.

Closed Spine

A closed spine is a flexed, concave posture. Shoulders curl slightly forward, knees come up, the torso compacts inward. The spine curves like the letter C. This posture shortens your lever arm — your body becomes a smaller, denser unit that is harder to rock, destabilize, or use against you. But the closed spine is not merely defensive. It is also a loaded position — coiled, compressed, and ready to release. When the hip joint opens from this contracted state, the body can expand explosively along its length. That sudden extension — from closed to open — is where guard players generate offensive power, shooting into leg entanglements, bridging, reversing. The closed spine stores the energy that the opening hip joint releases. And throughout, it keeps you protected — centerline guarded, body compact, nothing easy to grab or control.

Open Spine

An open spine is an extended, upright posture. The vertebrae stack vertically, hips align beneath shoulders, the body forms a rigid column. Think of a judoka driving through a throw or a wrestler completing a takedown. This posture creates a powerful rotational axis — the kind that generates turning, spinning, and driving force. When the spine is open and stacked, the hips can rotate freely around that vertical column, transferring force from the ground upward and outward with maximum efficiency. Rotational power lives in the open spine. But extension comes at a cost — an open spine exposes the centerline, lengthens the lever, and gives your opponent more to work with.

"A longer lever arm can generate more power. It can also be used against you."

The trade-off is not complicated. A closed spine protects you. An open spine empowers you. The question is which one the moment demands — and whether you've consciously chosen it, or just defaulted to habit.

CLOSED SPINE VS. OPEN SPINE – GENERAL TRADE-OFFS	
Closed Spine	
Open Spine	
STABILITY	
• Lower center of gravity • Shorter lever arm — harder to rock or sweep • Compact base resists destabilization	
	• Higher center of gravity • Longer lever arm — opponent can use your height against you • Requires active muscular engagement to maintain
POWER GENERATION	
• Explosive power through expansion — coil releasing • Hip joint opens from contracted state, driving length • Kinetic energy stored in flexion, released on extension • Source of offensive guard power: bridging, shooting, reversing	
	• Rotational power — turning, spinning, driving through • Full kinetic chain activation: ground → hips → limbs • Hips rotate freely around vertical spinal column • Ideal for throws, takedowns, and projecting force
PROTECTION	
• Centerline guarded • Vital organs tucked inward • Head and chin naturally protected	
	• Centerline exposed • Body opens to attack when fully extended • Requires defensive positioning to compensate
VULNERABILITY	
• Reduced mobility and reach • Cannot project significant force outward • Passive — requires opponent to come to you	
	• Easier for opponent to grip, sweep, or redirect • Susceptible to being pulled forward or rocked back • Demands precise footwork to maintain structure
KINETIC CHAIN	
• Chain is compressed and contained • Foot positioning anchors a tight, low base • Toes-inward posture supports hip alignment	

- Chain is extended and active
- Foot positioning creates rotational axis
- Duck foot or pigeon toe directly affects hip and spine alignment

BEST USED WHEN

- Playing guard — supine or seated
 - Defending passes and maintaining mobility
 - Absorbing or slipping attacks
 - In danger of being stacked or destabilized
- Executing throws and takedowns (Judo)
 - Passing guard from standing or top position
 - Creating forward pressure and driving through
 - Any moment demanding force projection

DIAGRAMS

Seeing the Framework

These diagrams illustrate the core mechanical differences between open and closed spine postures — the lever arm, the rocking quality, and how force travels through the body in each posture.

DIAGRAM 1 — OPEN SPINE VS. CLOSED SPINE

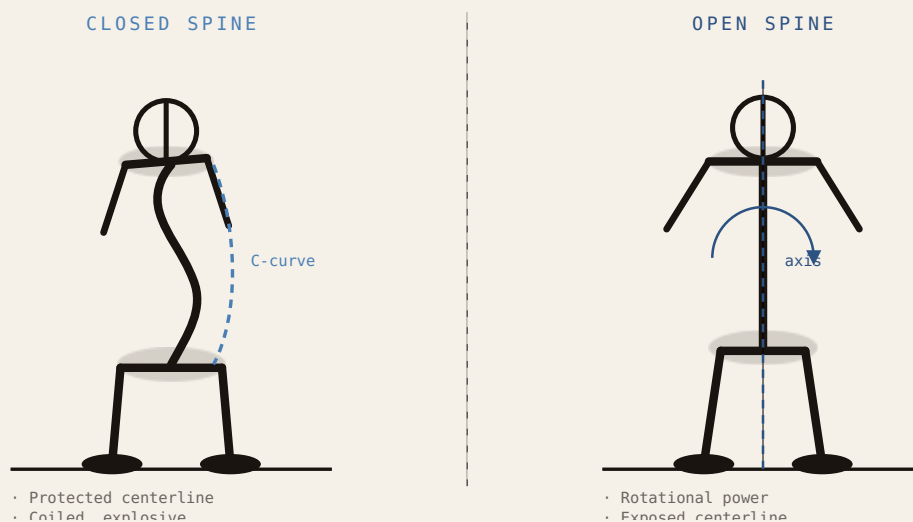


DIAGRAM 2 — THE LEVER ARM PRINCIPLE

CLOSED = SHORT LEVER

Hard to tip
→ stable



The longer the lever, the more force an opponent can generate at the pivot — your base.

OPEN = LONG LEVER

Easy to tip
→ vulnerable

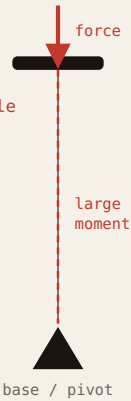
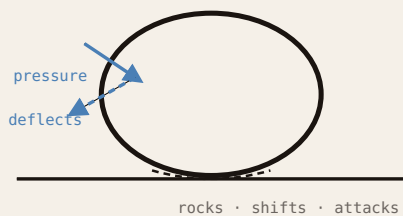
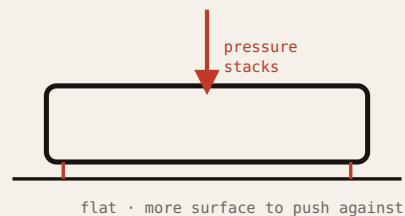


DIAGRAM 3 — THE ROCKING CHAIR VS. THE PLANK

CLOSED = ROCKING CHAIR



OPEN = THE PLANK



CASE STUDIES

The Framework in Action

Each of the following scenarios illustrates why the open/closed choice matters — and what goes wrong when practitioners default to the wrong one.

01

BRAZILIAN JIU-JITSU

Open Guard — The Rocking Chair Principle

VERDICT *Closed Spine*

Whether you are playing guard supine — flat on your back with legs active — or seated upright in open guard, the same postural demand applies: stay concave. High-level jiu-jiteiros are explicit about this in their instructional work. The guard player must maintain a curled, inward posture — knees drawn toward the chest, spine flexed, body compact. Become a ball.

The physics of why this works are simple and profound. A ball rocks. A flat surface gives your opponent more to work with — a stable plane to push against, more leverage at the base. The longer your lever arm, the more a directed force can affect you. An open spine in guard increases that risk.

A closed spine does the opposite. The concave posture creates a rocking chair effect: your opponent cannot find a stable surface to push against. You become round. Pressure slides off rather than accumulating. And critically, the closed posture keeps your hips mobile and your legs active. Your knees stay close to your chest, your frames stay loaded, and you can shift, invert, or attack from almost any angle. Mobility in guard is a product of concavity, not extension.

This holds whether you are supine or seated upright. The spine stays closed in both. And the closed spine is not merely defensive — it is coiled. A spring under tension. From that concave posture you can explode into offensive positions, shooting from supine into leg entanglements, recoiling and re-extending in a single motion. The closed spine stores energy. The moment you open up prematurely and extend, you lose both the rocking quality and the loaded potential that makes guard dangerous.

INSTRUCTOR CUE

"Be a ball, not a board. Round spines rock and create angles. Flat spines get stacked and passed. Stay concave — whether you're on your back or sitting up."

02

JUDO

The Throw — Upright Structure as the Engine

VERDICT *Open Spine*

Judo is built around the open spine. Kano's foundational principle — maximum efficiency, minimum effort — cannot be realized from a collapsed posture. To throw another person, your body must function as a vertical axis. The hips load, the legs drive, and that force travels up through an aligned spine and out through your grips. If the spine is flexed and the column compromised, the force dissipates before it reaches your opponent. You work harder and accomplish less.

This is why judoka train posture relentlessly. The upright stance — head over shoulders, shoulders over hips, hips over feet — is not aesthetic. It is mechanical. It is the condition under which the kinetic chain operates at full capacity. A throw like o-soto-gari or seoi-nage requires that vertical column to rotate around. Take the column away and you take the throw away.

Foot positioning matters here too. The planted foot during entry sets the rotational axis for the entire throw. Misaligned feet mean misaligned hips, which means a broken chain. Kano understood this intuitively — efficient movement begins at the ground and travels upward through a structure that is open, stacked, and ready to rotate.

INSTRUCTOR CUE

"You cannot throw from a slouch. The spine is the engine. Stand tall, load the hips, and let the structure do the work — not the arms."

03

DAILY LIFE • LONGEVITY

Standing, Sitting & Walking — Where It All Began

VERDICT *Open Spine*

This framework began with pain — not on the mat, but off it. Lower back pain. Shoulder tightness. Cervical stress. The kind that accumulates quietly over decades and one day announces itself. That pain was the question. The open spine in daily life is the answer.

The literature is clear and consistent on this: healthy posture — standing, sitting, walking — is an open spine. A decompressed column. Natural lumbar curve maintained. Head balanced freely over the shoulders. This is what Esther Gokhale documents in populations without chronic back pain in her foundational work ***8 Steps to a Pain-Free Back*** — a structural signature she calls the J-spine: upright sacrum, elongated back, no collapsed lumbar. It is what the Alexander Technique has trained since the early twentieth century through its central principle — free the neck, allow the head to go forward and up, allow the back to lengthen and widen. Different traditions, same conclusion. The healthy body in everyday movement is open.

For the practitioner with years on the mat, this is critical. Years of guard work, defensive postures, and the inevitable rounding of grappling train the body toward concavity. The closed spine — appropriate and powerful in its context — can become a default off the mat if it is not consciously counterbalanced. Standing rounds. Sitting collapses. Walking shortens. The pain that brought this inquiry to life was, in part, a closed spine that never fully opened again between sessions.

The open spine in daily life is not just good health practice. For the martial artist it is active recovery — resetting the structural baseline so that both open and closed postures remain genuine choices on the mat rather than compensations for what the body has defaulted to off it. Stand tall. Sit long. Walk with the spine open. This is how you stay on the mat into your fifties, sixties, and beyond.

WHERE THIS STARTED

"I wasn't trying to build a framework. I was trying to fix my back. The open spine in everyday life is the answer to the question that started all of this."

CLOSING

The Essential Question

Jigoro Kano built Judo on the principle of maximum efficiency with minimum effort. The same principle applies here — but only if you know which posture to be in. Defaulting to one spine position regardless of context is neither efficient nor intelligent. It's habit masquerading as technique.

The framework is simple: closed spine for stability, protection, and compactness; open spine for power, rotation, and force generation. Each has its place. Neither is universally correct. The question — ***open or closed, right now, for this?*** — is the thing worth training.

Ask it consciously enough times and it stops being a question. It becomes perception. And once you see it, you see it everywhere — in every throw, every sweep, every clinch, every scramble. Every movement has a spine. Every movement makes a choice.

[†] Justin Flores (J FLO), judoka, wrestler, and grappling coach. "Hand Fight and Pummel Like a Pro!" – the instructional video in which J FLO demonstrates the cue to turn toes inward for hip springiness that initiated this framework: youtu.be/bxetBY5vTE0 · jfloacademy.com · @jflojudo. The kinetic chain synthesis is the author's own.

^{*} Jigoro Kano (1860–1938), founder of Judo, articulated the principle of *seiryoku zen'yo* – maximum efficiency, minimum effort – as one of the two foundational principles of Judo alongside mutual welfare and benefit.

^{**} "Work smarter, not harder" was coined by Allen F. Morgenstern, an industrial engineer and creator of the Work Simplification Program, in the 1930s. The author first encountered this principle through Scrooge McDuck's father in DuckTales, Season 1, Episode 61, "Once Upon a Dime" (1987). The scholarly attribution belongs to Morgenstern. The personal attribution belongs to a cartoon duck.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Special acknowledgment to [Justin Flores \(J FLO\)](#) — 3x National Judo Champion, Division I All-American wrestler, Jiu-Jitsu black belt under Fabio Santos, 2020 USA Olympic team coach, and 3x UFC World Champion coach. A hybrid unlike any other: depth across Judo, wrestling, and Jiu-Jitsu, unified into a system that is both principled and practical. A model for teaching with integrity. His instruction on turning the toes inward to keep the hips springy was the cue that unlocked this entire inquiry. See: ["Hand Fight and Pummel Like a Pro!" — @JFLOJUDO ↗](#)

Thank you to every training partner, instructor, and opponent across thirty years on the mat. You are all in this framework whether you know it or not. Thank you to Justin Flores (J FLO) for a cue that unlocked something I had been circling for years.

ABOUT THIS WORK — A NOTE ON COLLABORATION

Carbon & Silicon

This piece was shaped in collaboration between carbon-based and silicon-based intelligence. I brought the framework, the thirty years of mat time, the pain that started the inquiry, and the voice. The AI supported with structure, prose, and the labor of getting it onto the page. It was like having an editor and a mirror at the same time.

The bottleneck has always been getting what lives in my body and my mind into clear written form. This process helped me move past that. Otherwise this framework would have remained untold — useful only to me, on the mat, in my own body.

CARBON

GEORGE · @GD0J095 · PRACTITIONER SINCE 1995

SILICON

CLAUDE · ANTHROPIC · AI COLLABORATOR

- Thirty years of BJJ training since 1995 — the lived experience behind the framework
- The original observation — inward toes, hip springiness, duck foot, anterior pelvic tilt
- The cross-disciplinary connections: Wing Chun, J FLO's hip cue, Judo structure, guard posture
- The rocking chair principle — concave posture in guard as structural insight
- The coiled spine concept — closed as loaded and explosive, not merely protective
- The synthesis: open or closed spine as the essential question every practitioner should ask
- The intellectual framing: Jigoro Kano's efficiency principle as the throughline
- The Scrooge McDuck footnote (non-negotiable)
- The purpose: longevity. Playing martial arts better, and longer.

- The voice: practitioner-to-practitioner. No ivory tower.

- Listening, pattern recognition, reflecting the framework back clearly
- Quick literature review to locate the discourse and identify the gap
- Confirming the Kano attribution and Morgenstern origin for "work smarter, not harder"
- Identifying the DuckTales episode: "Once Upon a Dime," Season 1, Episode 61
- Structuring the framework into definitions, T-chart, and case studies
- Writing and refining the prose, instructor cues, and diagrams across multiple drafts
- Designing and building the magazine layout with Gdojo branding
- Proofreading and editing throughout

This piece remains mine in responsibility. I own the choices and the voice. But I am grateful for the help, and I believe collaborations like this – with respect between carbon and silicon – can open new ways of telling our stories and sharing what we know.

This is a first draft. I wanted to get it out before fear kept it inside – before the pursuit of perfect became the enemy of done. So here it is, offered as is, to the community. Especially to those with discernment. You will know what to do with it.

In the words of Erykah Badu: *"I'm an artist and I'm sensitive about my shit."*

I hope we can refine, build, and develop from this together. An offering. That is all it is.

Thank you to my senseis. Thank you to my mentors and coaches. Thank you to my senpais. Thank you to my training partners. Thank you to my students. All of you are in this.

The mistakes are mine. What is truly useful and genuinely dope belongs to the Miracle and the Mystery.

"Knowledge is free. Understanding is earned. To earning understanding – and then sharing it with those who are open."

– George, @gdojo95

LICENSE



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